

Cat Severe Anxiety Home Management — Action Checklist

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MEDICATION MONITORING

- ☐ **Medication Monitoring:** Start a daily medication journal on the first day of treatment and record your cat's behavior, appetite, and anxiety episodes to track whether the medication is working.
- ☐ **Medication Monitoring:** Continue all prescribed medications through the full 4-6 week adjustment period even if your cat seems worse in weeks 1-2, since stopping early prevents the medication from reaching therapeutic levels.
- ☐ **Medication Monitoring:** Record side effects like lethargy, appetite changes, or difficulty with balance in your journal and note when they occur, since this information helps your vet judge whether dosage adjustments are needed.
- ☐ **Medication Monitoring:** Schedule a follow-up vet discussion at week 6 if you have not noticed meaningful improvement in baseline anxiety, since this is the realistic timeline for judging whether the medication is working.

DAILY MANAGEMENT

- ☐ **Daily Management:** Set up quiet, low-traffic hiding spaces in multiple rooms where your cat can retreat when feeling anxious, giving them control over their environment during the medication ramp-up phase.
- ☐ **Daily Management:** Administer gabapentin 1-2 hours before known stressful events like vet visits or thunderstorms, since the medication's immediate effects help prevent anxiety episodes before they escalate.
- ☐ **Daily Management:** Feed your cat at consistent times each day and note appetite changes in your journal, since decreased appetite is common during the first 2 weeks of SSRI treatment but worth tracking.
- ☐ **Daily Management:** Avoid forcing interaction with your cat for grooming or handling during the first 2 weeks of medication adjustment, since pushing contact during this period can increase anxiety and interfere with the medication's effectiveness.

VET COMMUNICATION

- ☐ **Vet Communication:** Review your medication journal before calling your vet to determine whether what you are observing matches the expected timeline of adjustment side effects versus signs the medication is not working.
 - ☐ **Vet Communication:** Contact your vet if your cat shows severe symptoms like extreme aggression toward people, prolonged lethargy lasting more than a few days, or refusal to eat for more than 24 hours.
 - ☐ **Vet Communication:** Bring your medication journal to every vet appointment so you can show concrete examples of what your cat's anxiety looks like day-to-day and whether episodes are improving or worsening.
 - ☐ **Vet Communication:** Ask your vet about piggybacking gabapentin or clonidine onto your cat's regimen if the fluoxetine has not taken full effect yet, since these medications can provide immediate relief while waiting for the SSRI to ramp up.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.